

Food Festivals Around the World

No celebration is complete without good food and drink, but sometimes the food or drink itself is the reason for a party. It may be to welcome the coming of spring or harvest time; to rejoice in the arrival of seasonal produce; to pay tribute to a traditional local skill; or simply to celebrate a feast day handed down through the generations. Whatever the reason, the next eight pages give just a taster of the tens of thousands of food festivals that take place each year around the world – the best, the oldest, the most rustic, and the quirkiest. To take part in any one of them is to get a real sense of the place and the people, and is an opportunity not to be missed.

JANUARY

EUROPE

St-Antoni Abat, Andorra

Perched high in the Pyrenees between France and Spain, Andorra keeps out the cold on St. Anthony's Day with huge vats of its national dish, *escudilla*, a meaty stew cooked on an open fire and served in the terra-cotta dish of the same name. Everyone is welcome to join in the feast.

St-Vincent Tournante, Burgundy, France

At the end of January, when the vines are bare and snow is often on the ground, the villages of the Burgundy region take turns lauding the patron saint of winemakers with colorful processions, solemn ceremony, and a great deal of conviviality and fine wine. www.st-vincent-tournante.fr

Burns Night, Scotland

The birthday of Scotland's national poet, Robert Burns, on January 25 is enthusiastically celebrated across the country with readings of his verse, dishes of haggis (see pp22–3), "neeps and tatties" (mashed rutabaga and potato), and, most importantly, a few drams of fine Scottish whiskey. www.robertburns.org/suppers

ASIA AND AUSTRALASIA

Auckland Seafood Festival, New Zealand

Auckland honors its fishing heritage with the biggest seafood festival in New Zealand. After a ceremonial blessing of the fleet, the harbor becomes a licensed market where visitors can sample the freshest seafood, matched with local wines and beers. www.aucklandseafoodfestival.co.nz

Blues, Brews and BBQs, Mount Maunganui, Hastings, and Blenheim, New Zealand

Celebrate the Kiwi summer in style at this community-oriented festival, held over three Saturdays in different towns. Top New Zealand blues bands entertain the ear, locally brewed beers, ciders, and wines amuse the palate, and gourmet chefs prepare barbecue to satisfy every taste. www.bluesbrews.co.nz

NORTH AMERICA

Niagara Icewine Festival, Canada

Over three weekends in January, Canada's vine-growing region celebrates its famous Ontario Icewine (produced from grapes

left to freeze on the vine) with vineyard tours, tastings at alfresco ice bars, warming chestnut roasts, and Cellar Room dinners that pair award-winning wines with mouthwatering dishes and fine local cheeses. www.niagarawinefestival.com

Cayman Cookout, Grand Cayman, Cayman Islands

Not as rustic as it sounds, this festival of food and wine in the idyllic setting of the Cayman Islands is an exercise in contrasts – for example, when a "beach barbecue" is hosted by a world-renowned chef. A once-in-a-lifetime experience – heavenly cuisine in a tropical paradise. www.caymanislands.ky

Mendocino County Crab & Wine Days, California, USA

It's the height of the Dungeness crab season on Mendocino County's coastline, and these seven seafood-filled days feature everything from an all-you-can-eat Crab Feed to a Crab Cake Cookoff, with tastings to help match local wines to the food. www.mendocino.com

SOUTH AMERICA

Fiesta Nacional de Chivo, Mendoza, Argentina

The Feast of the Goat is Argentina's biggest food festival. Over 1,000 kid goats are roasted *asado*-style over open fires in a week-long extravaganza of meat, fire, and folk music. At daily gaucho shows, Argentinian cowboys display remarkable feats of horsemanship.

Costumbrista Chilote, Chiloé, Chile

On this misty, magical archipelago, legend and ceremony come together in the traditional dish *curanto* (see pp314–5), and never more so than during Chiloé's annual celebration of island life and culture. The earth-oven-baked meat and fish sustained islanders against the lure of mermaids and trolls – folklore performances recount the tales.



FEBRUARY

EUROPE

Fête du Citron, Menton, France

After the Carnival of Nice, the biggest event on the Riviera is the spectacular Menton Citrus Festival. Over 150 tons of lemons, limes, and oranges are displayed as magnificent creations – from smiling Buddhas to marauding dinosaurs – on parades of gargantuan floats. www.feteducitron.com

Rye Bay Scallop Week, East Sussex, UK

The Cinque Port of Rye yields some of the finest scallops in the country, and this festival combines award-winning wines with music and eight days of events, from scallop-cutting, preparing, cooking, and tasting to the wheelbarrow-pushing "What a Load of Scallops" race. www.ryebayscallops.co.uk

Fiera del Cioccolato, Florence, Italy

The premier artisan chocolatiers of Tuscany come together once a year in Florence's historic and beautiful Piazza della Croce to display their skills and their wares. Visitors can watch these masters of their art at work and, of course, sample some of the finest chocolate creations in the world.

Brez'n Angeln, Oberammergau, Germany

Oberammergau is famed for spiritual sustenance in its Passion Play, but for food of a more earthly kind, it goes "Pretzel Fishing." Townsfolk in traditional dress, accompanied by a marching band, tour the town in a horse-drawn cart from which fresh-baked pretzels are dangled on rod and line. Everyone has to jump like fish to snatch a savory treat.

THE MIDDLE EAST AND AFRICA

Prickly Pear Festival, Port Elizabeth, South Africa

Strangely, on South Africa's famous Garden Route, they make a big fuss about a little fruit once considered an "alien undesirable." So much so that 16 tons of prickly pears are processed for the festival – into preserves, chutneys, candy, and *witblits*, a fiery spirit that is only legally distilled right here.

